and 2026, respectively. FGD can reduce SO_2 emissions from thermal power plants by 50-90 per cent depending on age. Given the short supply of FGDs and the trouble in retrofitting them, it is now estimated that most of these targets for ensuring FGD in all thermal power plants will be met only by 2032. This, when we need these norms to be implemented on a war footing.

Clean coal technologies in the pre-combustion process of coal mining, handling and transportation, in the combustion and finally the post-combustion (handling of fly ash) stages was another measure the Centre had mandated in order to curb pollution from coal-based power plants. One such technology is the coal washing process, which not only enhances its heating potential but also helps reduce the sulphur content and other hazardous air pollutants. India currently has 20 operational washeries, with a capacity of 113.6 million tonnes per annum. However, in May 2020, the MoEFCC amended the Environment Protection Act to permit thermal power plants to do their own washing as well. Washing en route or at the point of alignment, it was felt, added to the pollution. Implementation, yet again, remains the key hurdle in the realisation of good intentions. ■

CONSTRUCTION

A Building Frenzy

The infrastructure boom has led to unregulated construction activity. The solution is not a total ban, but a graded response plan



SUMIT KUMAR